PSCI 330

1. In Gerring et al.'s article, "Are parliamentary systems better?" the authors conclude that: "In most policy areas, particularly in the areas of economic and human development, parliamentary systems are associated with superior governance." Why do they reach this conclusion? Do you believe that the U.S. would be better off, worse off, or that there would be no difference if we adopted a parliamentary system of government? Be sure to cite specific examples from the reading that illustrate the points you are making.

Gerring et al.'s paper discusses the constraints a presidential system may subject a governance's legislative powers to, while a parliamentary system could prove to be more effective in policy-making. It argues that there is a correlation between decisive policy-making and the cohesion of party allegiances. In a system where the executive power is independently elected, it is believed that the checks and balances between the branches of government will prevent infringement on individual freedoms (Gerring et al. 2009, 10). An individualistic mindset within governance perpetrates tension, causing misalignment in party interests and ultimately weakening the organization. Although it is unclear whether strong political parties positively influence a government overall, there are apparent downsides to a lack of bipartisan cooperation that a presidential system can induce. Some examples include complications in electoral accountability, pacing with the changes in political/socio-economic climate, and inattentiveness to the public majority. Gerring et al.'s investigation of the comparison of the two systems relies on empirical evidence in order to determine its conclusion. The authors found that the unification of the legislative and executive branches contributes to higher levels of human development (lower infant mortality and longer life expectancy) and economic growth (more inclined to international trade, greater levels of per capita GDP, etc.)(Gerring et al. 2009, 248-249). Therefore, the authors dubbed the parliamentary system as the superior structure due to its favor of collectivism: "To this end, we put forth, provisionally and broadly, that what

distinguishes parliamentarism from presidentialism—and what makes the former a more reliable vehicle for good public policy—is its capacity to function as a coordination device" (Gerring et al. 2009, 353-354).

I personally believe that a parliamentary system would benefit the United States. Currently, it is evident that there is a political divide in America:

> Why has the U.S. become so much more polarized? [Jesse] Shapiro said it may be partly because, since the 1970s, major political parties have become increasingly aligned with certain ideologies, races and religious identities. For example, Republicans are now more likely to be religious, while Democrats are more likely to be secular (Kimball 2020).

With the rapidly ever-changing political climate, policy-making should reduce polarization between political ideologies while preserving the voice of the individual. However, if I were to provide an answer less confined to the nature of the question, I would instead say that a hybrid system would be the most advantageous. A hybrid system may be able to promote a general consensus in tandem with protecting the interests of the public minority, reducing the uprise of extremist regimes.

3. After September 11 in the United States, government buildings became much more secure, and it became much more difficult for citizens to enter them. Compare the security in the government sites that we visited in Japan to that you are used to in the U.S. Did you notice any differences? If so, what explains those differences? What is your reaction to them?

While in Japan, I realized many buildings had minimal to no security. This includes commercial buildings, government sites, academic institutions, and to some extent, the Tokyo-Haneda International Airport. Similarly to the United States, commercial or retail buildings may have a security system to detect or deter shoplifting. However, I did not observe

as many products under lock and key compared to American retail chains. Some of the government sites had surveillance from cameras and guards, in addition to a brief bag check/metal detector test at the entrance (depending on the building). Comparatively, the intensity of the security in American government sites is equivalent to or exceeds what I experienced in Japan. In some American government buildings, I've had to turn off any technological/internet-accessible devices on my person. Also, many government buildings in America rely on extra architectural security, such as fences. These observations overlap with the comparison of security in airports and academic institutions– overall, the United States has stricter regulations of what is permitted in such places.

Despite shoplifting being one of the most common criminal offenses in Japan, the punishment is more steep than the charges mandated by American courts. In the United States, shoplifting is generally considered to be a misdemeanor (varies by the severity of the offense and state it occurred in), resulting in a couple of months in jail and several thousand in court fines and fees (Court of the Attorney General 2025). On the other hand, Japan's penalty for larceny is imprisonment for at least 10 years or a minimum fee of 500,000 yen (~3,236.50 USD)(Queckfeldt 2023, 45). Therefore, Japan relies more on informal surveillance methods to combat theft (social expectations, its high conviction rate/steep penalties, etc.) than formal ways (security system and guards). As for buildings that are at risk for terrorism, such as government sites and airports, Japan utilizes formal surveillance approaches to ensure safety. Nonetheless, I perceive Japan's security measures to be less obtrusive than the United States' standards. This leads to the question: "Why are both countries highly industrialized and urbanized, yet Japan has significantly reduced the presence of serious crime?". The answer is two main contributing factors: the high professional standard of Japanese police officials and the strict ban on firearms

(Clifford 1980, 15). Grass-root approaches, such as encouraging cooperation between the Police Corp and the general public and enforcing anti-crime initiatives in schools, have been acknowledged as effective in the deterrence of crime.

6. Should the U.S. have dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki? Justify your answer using (and citing) specific information you learned in the Hiroshima Peace Memorial and Museum and through our meeting with the A-bomb survivor.

I do not believe the Allies required the deployment of the atomic bomb to win the war. In fact, I find that nationalistic intentions in gaining a technological advantage over Germany and the USSR played a discernible role in the execution of the Manhattan Project. My claim is supported by the attitude Americans held post-war regarding Hiroshima and Nagasaki. From Operation Paperclip to the submersion into the Cold War, the race to metamorphose into a globally-recognized nuclear powerhouse catalyzed the abandonment of ethics for a calloused, chauvinistic mentality:

> The most recent instance of this cognitive gap occurred in December 1994, and revolved around the projected "mushroom cloud stamp" with the legend "Atom bombs hasten war's end, August 1945." The design and caption "irritated the rawest nerve in the Japanese psyche, triggering shock, anger, outrage and threats." Japanese mass media and political leaders, not to mention the mayors of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, joined the nationwide chorus denouncing the stamp as "heartless" and justifying the use of the bomb. (Sadao 1995, 100).

This excerpt highlights the contrast between the American and Japanese perceptions of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Many Americans adopted the “Truman Orthodoxy”, which can be described as: “....President Truman publicly stated that the bombs had been used to end the war quickly and thus save American lives that would have been sacrificed in any invasion of Japan's

home islands…that the decision was necessary and justified by military reasons…"(Sadao 1995, 98). The "Truman Orthodoxy" interpretation of the A-bomb usage was defended through two arguments: 1) rationalized as an alternative to a land invasion, therefore minimizing the casualties on the American side, and 2) retaliation for Pearl Harbor. Conversely, the Japanese people (especially survivors) did not have the same luxury of celebrating post-war peacebuilding due to the mortifying, transgenerational repercussions of the atomic bomb. The physical, psychological, and emotional impact of the radioactive devastation incited the Japanese to pursue peace initiatives for nuclear non-proliferation.

The Hiroshima legacy survivor touched on several ubiquitous beliefs pertinent to the Japanese perception of the A-bomb. In his presentation, he used visual aids– art pieces and photographs– as a mouthpiece to amplify his peace-driven sentiment. Many of the images he displayed on his slides were ones I recognized, such as Hiroshima survivor Yoshimura Kichisuke's visual representation of his eye-witness account and the photograph of the woman who suffered from burn dermagraphed in the pattern of the kimono she wore. Although I am familiar with the A-bomb incidents, listening to the recount of events from a survivor was much different than reading information about it from a textbook. Between his perspective and the visual documentation I could only express my construal on Little Boy's destruction as a "nightmarish hellscape". I find it admirable that many Japanese people choose to advocate for peace, rather than to chase vengeance.

9. Michael Auslin writes: "Only in very recent times have some cultures actively attempted to engage with others, embracing exchange as a way to solidify political relations, develop their economies, defeat traditional enemies, or deepen their own cultural traditions. Among those thousands of exchanges, few have been as consequential and long-lasting as that between the United States and Japan" (Auslin 2011, 2). Why is the relationship between the U.S. and Japan so

important to each country?

The US-Japan relationship is sustained by cultural exchange and mutual economic prosperity or development. From a cultural standpoint, Japan and the United share numerous traditions and consumer products, ranging from entertainment to food to technology: “Yet walk into any American college today, and you will find a class on Japanese studies.Within those classes the overwhelming majority watching Japanese animation…those students will often while away the hours playing Nintendo…”(Auslin 2011, 5). Japanese entertainment, such as animation and video games, are now a crucial part of American popular culture. This acceptance of Japanese media has heavily influenced that of America, sparking creativity and inspiring the entertainment/media industries. As Auslin explains, this feeling is mutual. The integration of iconic American fast-food restaurants and blockbuster movies in Japanese society is proof of the bilateral cultural exchange. Additionally, this interchange is not met with resistance or aversion. The cultural exposure is stimulated through interactive activities, like study abroad programs or traveling exhibitions.

US-Japan relations are advantageous from an economic standpoint as well: “Together they account for over 30% of world domestic product, for a significant portion of international trade in goods and services, and for a major portion of international investment”(Cooper 2014, 1). The United States and Japan are both major economic powers– highly industrialized and have the ability to influence foreign trade on a global scale. One of the mutually beneficial aspects of the US-Japan economic partnership is the exported/imported goods and services. Japan’s exports consist of approximately three-quarters of cars, computers and components, and office machinery parts. Meanwhile, America’s exports to Japan are primarily (yet similarly) computers and components, gas turbines, and optical and medical equipment (Cooper 2014, 4).

Alongside the reciprocal media consumption, there is a technological co-dependency between the two countries. These two factors are essential for maintaining the quality of American and Japanese day-to-day lives.

10. Traveling in another country provides the opportunity not only to learn about another culture but also to reflect about one's homeland. Are there things you observed in Japan that have challenged and/or reaffirmed your attitudes about life in the U.S.? How has traveling in Japan affected your perceptions of both the U.S. and Japan?

Since my other entries have been source-heavy so far, I planned to exclusively use my own insights and refrain from using a substantial amount of external sources or information in this entry. Observations that stood out to me the most were in regard to the urban infrastructure and behaviors. Firstly, I was pleasantly surprised by the cleanliness and prevalence of public restrooms, unlike what I've experienced in Western countries. Japan strongly emphasizes good hygiene, which was evident in public restroom tidiness, wearing a medical mask if sick, and using a tray when exchanging money with a cashier. Furthermore, the expectation of carrying trash around due to the lack of garbage bins was inconvenient but, is an impressive strategy for keeping streets clean (plus, the fine for littering can be millions of yen– yikes!). The lack of homeless people in densely populated areas was an unfamiliar concept as well, possibly an attribute of Japan's small wealth gap.

Knowing the nature of my country, I am not convinced that America is capable of adopting similar practices. According to my observations, I surmised that Japan and America experience extreme, yet opposing forms of apathy. If an American did not have access to a trashcan, many would simply litter instead. The homeless population are ignored or even ridiculed, and I have witnessed biohazardly coughing, sneezing, and sputtering from people with little to no regard for their surroundings. This individualistic mindset is rooted in narcissism:

"Why should I care if it doesn't directly affect me?". This mentality is reflected in the polarization and hyperpartisanship in American governance, resulting in congressional gridlock and political unrest (e.g. January 6th insurrection, the assassination attempt against now-elected President Donald Trump in July 2024, and legislation on divided issues such as immigration). From my understanding of Japanese society, their apathy originates from collective nihilism. Apparent in Japan's Judicial Passivism and struggles with work-life balance, this attitude has caused reservations in the advocacy for change. Consequently, Japan suffers from a declining population, a high suicide rate, and an alcoholism problem.

MUSC 243

3. Japan has suffered devastating destruction over the course of its history due to natural disasters and war. We will confront a profound example in our travels: the atomic bomb attacks of 1945 (our visit to Hiroshima). Recognizing that you are an outside observer, what is your sense of the role the arts have played in the recovery from these terrible events?

The arts, specifically the visual arts, played a major role in conveying the tragedy of the atomic bomb from different perspectives. Many of these portrayals of the event are in drawing form, serving the purpose of not only relaying the severity of its aftermath but, as a means for emotional or mental healing as well. The artwork is a product of survivors of all ages, from children to those well into adulthood. I noticed there were two main depictions of the event: the first being the appearance of the explosion itself and its biological consequences as the second.

There was a specific example that was especially noticeable to me. In the museum, there were various drawings made by children aged roughly six to ten years old. One of the drawings in this series is an illustration of one of the atomic bomb explosions, drawn as a rainbow. At first, I thought the picture was an illustration of peace/a peaceful future. However, this didn't make sense in the context of the other pieces, which used imagery predominantly of mushroom clouds,

red fire, and black dust. The rainbow is surrounded by dark colors and clouds, leading me to the assumption that it is a depiction of the bombing. I found this particularly disturbing considering rainbows typically symbolize harmony, peace, and stability— juxtaposing the horrors witnessed at the atomic bomb sites. I surmised that a child may interpret the mushroom cloud as a rainbow due to its flash of light emitted upon deployment. Since a rainbow is a familiar concept to a child, that might be the simplest approach to describe such a terrifying and unprecedented sight. Although a younger survivor may struggle to fully comprehend or communicate the full implications of the atomic bomb, it does not diminish the significance of the psychological trauma inflicted.

To summarize, the atomic bomb had effects that transcended that of the visible eye. The pictures documenting the event showcase the physical damage, to both infrastructure and civilians, while the artwork contained a more nuanced message. It is a mouthpiece for all those who have suffered from the horrific damages on a psychological, or emotional level, alongside as a warning for the use of nuclear weapons in the future.

4. Anthropologist David Young has noted that Japanese aesthetics reflect two seemingly contradictory traditions: "restraint" and "exuberance." In our travels, choose two examples of Japanese culture (art, architecture, fashion, food, music, theatre) that you think reflect these concepts. Explain why.

In the context of Japanese culture, I conceptualize "restraint" with contemporary trends or expectations prevalent among its conservative, homogeneous society while traditional practices or counterculture can be categorized as "exuberance" due to its flamboyancy. Anecdotally, I noticed that Japan's fashion culture and architecture are polarized and exhibit a duality of "restraint" and "exuberance", rather than explicitly one or the other. The fashion culture has heavily transformed since the Meiji Restoration and World War II in accordance to

Western influences. Kimonos and Yukatas are not modern daily wear and instead, have been replaced in favor of corporate professionalism, opting for simplicity and uniformity: “On one hand it is a culture ruled by regimental uniformity and patriarchal values, perhaps best exemplified by the figures of the ‘salaryman’ or the ‘high school student’, where freedom of individual expression is a luxury”(Monden 2014, 1). As a result, adorning traditional garments is less practical for an office setting. Counterculture is the alter ego to normalized Japanese fashion customs, loosely conceptualized in specialized subcultures. These fashion subcultures, as observed in dedicated neighborhoods such as Harajuku in Tokyo, use self-expression and rejection of conformity as the basis for their communities. Each subculture depends on a fundamental set of aesthetics, ranging from excessive gothic belts and chains to bright, hypnotizing accessories.

Architecture is another compelling example of uniform pragmatism versus diverse aesthetics. During our visit to Japan, I realized that urban architecture utilized vertical space– specifically commercial and living spaces. Commercial buildings are multi-layered, spanning from the sky to underground with each floor componentized for individual sellers. This compact, practical infrastructure can be noted in living spaces as well. Tenant or apartment living spaces are popular in Japan due to its high population density in urban areas. On the other hand, traditional structures, such as temples or shrines, tend to be extravagant structures, unlike their contemporary counterparts. Civic and business buildings are unexpected examples of “exuberance” and demonstrate diversity in aesthetics. This is credited to the experimental approaches pursued in earthquake and fire prevention in urban areas, especially for cities residing on major faults such as Tokyo: “ Technological developments in both design and construction techniques allowed architects to experiment with new concepts in a way that was

consistent with the emphasis upon individualism and self-expression that swept Japan after the war."(Young and Young 2024, 326-327). Although the uniformity present in Japanese society can be characterized as "restraint", the divergence from the conventional has allowed for the emergence of standout uniqueness and individuality in various facets of its culture. This manifestation of "exuberance" is reflected from the past, including the Buddhist and Shinto-related influences in traditional Japan, in tandem to the forward-thinking counterculture that rejects societal norms.

6. In Tokyo we visited an exhibit dedicated to film (National Film Archive). What overall messages did the exhibit communicate about Japanese film? In your entry, summarize the kinds of materials that were preserved in the museum. Did you encounter any commentary/displays about music and film? If so, what was it? If not, why do you think it was excluded?

The National Film Archive discussed film's involvement in embracing technological advancements, adjusting to Western influences, and its exploitation as a propaganda tool during and post-WWII Japan**. The emergence of propaganda originated through the standardization of film censorship nationwide by the Ministry of Home Affairs Police Bureau in 1925. In 1939, this sentiment was established more firmly with the parliament's approval of the "Film Law". Alongside implementing restrictions on film content, the legislation enforced mandatory broadcasts of culture films and newsreels ("Nippon News"). The objective of the "Film Law" was to negate critical or negative interpretations of Japanese society in foreign-made films through illiberal restrictions and script censorship. As a result, the Ministry of Home Affairs Police Bureau published an annual record acknowledged as the "Censor Report", denoting the censored content in imported films. This was an approach to solidify public morality. In wartime,

the compulsory telecasting of newsreels warranted the release of propaganda to continuously protect Japan's image.

New technologies aided in the domestic circulation of propaganda. For instance, the film manufacturing company Natco's portable film projector (for 16mm sound film) was initially used to distribute propaganda during WWII. In 1947, Japan's Civil Information and Education Section (CIE) dispersed approximately a thousand portable film projectors throughout Japan. These projectors screened films produced in the US ("Natoko-eiga") to encourage Japan's postwar democratization.

Commentary excluded from the National Film Archive's exhibit was information regarding the role of mascotization of propaganda and protest in Japan. Kyarakutaa ("character"), or anthropomorphized representations of concepts or places, is a method frequently used by Japan to promote tourism, advertise to consumers, or relay information from an organization. Kyarakutaa, or their "cuter" imitations "yuru-kyara", is present in all forms of media– including film. To exemplify, Monju kun[1] is an unofficial parody character for the Monju power plant, assisting in the mobilization of the non-proliferation and resistance to nuclear power: "...the case of Monju Kun shows us that this aesthetic can also be used to mobilize sentiment against government and industry in protesting to end Japanese reliance on nuclear power and to promote sustainable energy generation."(Occhi 2013, 2). I personally believe the most popular politically-motivated kyarakutaa in film is Godzilla, because of the movie's anti-nuclear narrative. To conclude, the National Film Archive was a very interesting experience in furthering my understanding of the versatility of film in politics and culture.

**The following information was provided by the National Film Archive. I wasn't sure how to properly cite the information, so I felt like leaving a sidenote would be best.

[1] (Images of Monju-kun, from @monjukun, Twitter. Courtesy @monjukun,... | Download Scientific Diagram)



7. We visited many shrines and temples in Japan: large and small, extravagant and modest. Which ones did you find most memorable? What did you learn from these visits about the importance of these sites? How was that importance expressed in the sites themselves? What role did sound and/or music have at the sites?

My favorite site we visited was the Fushimi Inari shrine. Its memorability lies in the grandiosity and intricacy of the features of the shrine. I was amazed at the vastness of the innumerable Torii gates, which appeared to span infinitely heavenward up the mountainside. As I walked through the tunnels of gates, I noticed the contrast in age between some of the individual structures. Older gates were more withered and faded in color, with chunks of wood missing from the sides. Meanwhile, the newer gates were whole in form, coated in a shiny, smooth layer of paint that matched the shade of their worn counterparts. I spent much of my time in the shrine

contemplating the numerous, plausible methods for maintenance and general upkeep of the borderline-infinite collection of Torii gates.

Including the Fushimi Inari shrine, the temples and shrines share a commonality in which they hold a ceremonious value. The temples are places to worship Buddha or Bodhisattvas and the Shinto shrines are dedicated to various deities. For example, the Fushimi Inari shrine displays fox imagery. This indicates that it is a religious structure for Inari (fox deity) prayer and worship. Additionally, temples and shrines may have areas for graveyards.

While attending some of the religious sites, music was present in different forms. Live performances served ritualistic purposes, involving instruments such as drums and flutes, accompanied by choreography. I noticed that some of the sites— such as the Mitaki-dera temple— played music on a speaker. This seemed to be for ambiance or to influence the temples' atmosphere. The temples or shrines that utilized speakers tended to be a little more commercialized or tourist-centric than the locations that did not. Regardless, the temples and shrines all featured buildings to conduct prayer or worship.

8. Reflect on the kabuki performance we saw. Think about the entire experience: the theater space, the audience, the set and acting styles, and of course the music. How did the music contribute to the performance?

The Kabuki-za Theater has features unique to its space that are unlike those of Western proscenium stages. An example of an outstanding characteristic is the extended stage called a Hanamichi runway. The Hanamichi runway is a walkway used by actors to make entrances or exits, and it extends from the downstage right (or shimote). While on the runway, a character is spotlighted, both mentally by the audience and often physically by the lighting crew. Another interesting detail of the kabuki stage is the mawari-butai, or the revolving, circular platform on the center stage (Kabuki Official Website 2025). This enables the audience 360-degree

viewability of the set, in addition to simplifying the set change process. For each of the performances, the scenery appeared to be ornate and complex, resulting in little to no set changes. Therefore, the mawari-butai is an exciting solution to remedy the difficulty of set changes. Western theatre adopted this technology, as demonstrated in Broadway's original production of *My Fair Lady* in 1956 (Playbill 2023).

The etiquette the kabuki audience follows differentiates from the average American theatre standards. In a kabuki theatre, the audience is permitted to shout at the actors– in a supportive manner. This tradition, known as kakegoe, deepens the actor-audience relationship for a more intimate, interactive experience (Kabuki Official Website 2025). When an audience member engages with an actor through kakegoe, they yell out the actor's 'acting house' name.

Music is played by the musicians either on-stage or off-stage. When on stage, the musicians can be observed playing instruments, such as the shamisen, flute, or percussion (e.g. a tsuke "clapper" produces sound effects as an actor hurries across the stage). On the other hand, musicians also perform off-stage– in a room recognized as the kuromisu (Kabuki Official Website 2025). Musicians in the kuromisu specialize substantially in sound effects and control the atmosphere or mood in a scene. Kabuki theater utilizes many aspects of traditional Japanese storytelling, as evident in the music and the presentation of the actors (voice training, make-up, costuming, etc.). Incorporating traditional practices ultimately distinguishes Kabuki from Western theatre.

Personal entries/topics

1. Role of "geek" or "nerd" culture: America versus Japan

An observation I noticed while in Japan was the cognitive gap between Americans and their perception of "nerd culture" in Japan. Other than well-renowned companies such as

Nintendo and mainstream anime franchises, the availability of anime and video game paraphernalia is not as ubiquitous as retailers in the United States. For example, I could waltz into any Walmart or Target store and buy a Goku figure and a Demon Slayer T-shirt. With some exceptions, most anime merchandise in Japan can be bought in a Book-Off, tourist-friendly areas like Akihabara, or from the occasional gachapon machine. This realization, although based on anecdotal evidence, contradicts the preconceptions many of my peers have expressed regarding Japan's popular culture. A common line of thinking is: "Anime originated there, so it must be fundamental to their culture!". A little bit of a cringy sentiment but, I would be lying if I were to discredit my own feelings of surprise. It inclined me to address the question: "What is the reason behind the general disinterest towards "nerd" or *otaku* culture in Japan, and what has caused the dissonance in the American perception of Japanese popular culture?". With synergistic efforts between external resources and my deductive reasoning, I contrived an answer. It's because Japanese society views otakus as *losers*.

Harsh, I know. It's a pretty subjective claim as well– but, I have supporting evidence. This stigmatization of otaku-ism is due to its overlap with NEET (widely-used acronym, standing for "not in education, employment, or training") and hikikomori behaviors. To elaborate, there is a strong correlation between those who indulge in anime or manga and being unproductive or reclusive members of society:

> They are more dependent on the online world; they prefer communication via Internet, and they use online communication for almost all purposes: to see animation and movies, to download music, to access information, and many others. They prefer online shopping as well. They have reduced interpersonal and social skills which are not conducive to physical and mental health. (B-Ikeguchi 2018, 247)

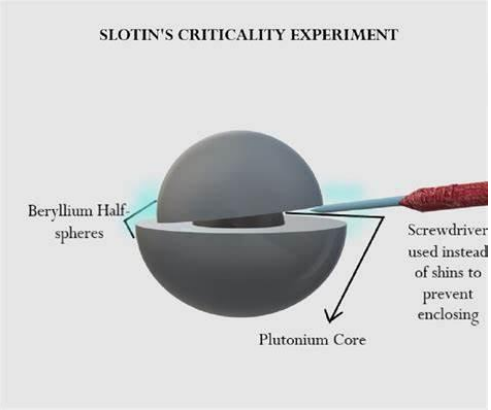
This issue is considered to be a youth crisis in Japan due to its darker implications. There is a strong suspicion that the obsession with fictional escapism is related to a slew of unaddressed mental health conditions and personality problems: "They create their own little fantasy world filled with anime "bishounens" and "rabu-rabu" and this schizotypal tendency hinders them from creating "normal" relationships, thus making them school outcasts and bottom feeders of the social food chain" (B-Ikeguchi 2018, 251).

America's "nerd culture" harbors similar issues in the younger generation, such as reclusive social behaviors and communication complications. However, the difference from Japan's otakus lies in the popularization of "nerd" franchises and hobbies in America. By positively depicting the nerd stereotype in media, the popularization and the normalization of largely recognized "geek" idiosyncrasies have occurred: "While we may not see ourselves as the lost boys out of Idaho, or the quirky characters in *The Big Bang Theory*…we begin to sympathize with these characters' struggles to establish themselves in a social community"(Lane 2018, 73). Through media, the audience can empathize with a character's quirkiness and in some cases, experience relatability to their feelings of ostracization. "Nerd" culture appeals to a broader audience and reduces the stigmatization of geekiness as a result. Therefore, modern American media is a vehicle for exposing various facets of the nerd stereotype, ranging from niche or unconventional hobbies to insecurities relating to being a social outcast, to a mass audience. This may explain the disconnection between the reception of Japanese and American "nerd" pop culture in their respective countries (in addition to the misconceptions arising from the international success of the manga and anime entertainment industry).

2. A continuation of the Hiroshima discussion from the perspective of a physics major

In my major, the ethics of physics in relation to the controversy of the A-bomb has been a topic brought up on numerous occasions. I want to use this journal entry to further highlight the contrasting attitudes of America and Japan towards nuclear weapons. In particular, the demon core and its criticality incidents came to mind during my time in the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Museum. The demon core was a sphere of fissile plutonium material designed to be the third atomic bomb dropped in the situation that Japan refused to surrender again. Postwar experimentation on the unused core resulted in two criticality events, in which the latter instance was caused by flagrant carelessness. In 1946, Los Alamos scientist Louis Slotin was performing his experiment per usual– which he dubbed “tickling in the dragon’s tail”(Atomic Heritage Foundation 2022). The experimental apparatus consisted of only the demon core and a single screwdriver to separate the beryllium hemispheres. His objective was to bring the core as close to criticality as possible using the tip of his screwdriver.

Image of apparatus: (What Exactly Is A Demon Core And Why Is It So Infamous?)



If you’re thinking this is sloppy science, it’s because it is– and there is no fairytale ending. On that day in 1946, Louis Slotin’s screwdriver slipped and the infamous blue flash illuminated the room: "His comment to one of his co-workers was, 'You'll be OK, but I think I'm done for.' He knew right away what had happened to him.”(American Physics Society 2014). He

died nine days later from radiation poisoning. In an earlier journal entry, I mentioned the "Truman Orthodoxy" and the general attitude towards Hiroshima and Nagasaki from the American public. I wonder if this mindset influenced Slotin to recklessly toy with a decommissioned weapon of mass destruction, despite the atomic bomb droppings occurring barely a year earlier. Some sources claim it was his eccentric personality that solidified his fate: "Slotin was a bit of a daredevil, a former amateur boxer who favored jeans and cowboy boots, and told tales of his days as an anti-aircraft gunner during the Spanish Civil War–although his brother later said that Slotin had actually just been on a walking tour through Spain, and played no part in the war."(American Physics Society 2014)). After my time in Hiroshima's museum, I don't believe his demise in the second criticality accident can be chalked up to his eccentric personality. I found the consequences too disconcerting to be ignored, leaving me to believe that wartime nationalism may have caused cognitive dissonance in Slotin. It is a possible explanation for such a mistake that was negligent and preventable, especially with the knowledge of the extent of its destructive powers.

3. Public Transportation: From bird calls to station-personalized jingles

On a more lighthearted note, I was smitten with the variety of bird calls and station-personalized jingles that played in the train stations. Naturally, I was curious about the intention behind these noises. I noticed the sounds played in two instances: repeatedly near the staircases and on the platform whenever a train approached or left. Apparently, the "ding-dongs" near the ticket gates and bird-chirping at the staircases are assistive technology for the visually impaired (ONO SOKKI 2025). It alerts them of their location in proximity to these areas of the train station. Other examples of assistive technology are the chime indicator for opening and closing doors on the train and an escalator-guidance sound. A critique of this system is that

utilizing too many different sounds may cause the noises to overlap, confusing a visually impaired person (ONO SOKKI 2025).

As previously mentioned, a noticeable pattern was the individualized jingles for each stop on a line. I learned about the composer responsible for creating over a hundred of the customized station jingles, known as “hassha merodi”: Minoru Mukaiya. Mukaiya claims his jingles are psychological tricks to aid with the efficiency of passengers entering and exiting the train: "There is a huge number of people who take the train in the metropolitan areas such as Tokyo, Osaka and Nagoya and it's necessary to get people on and off in a short time” (Sturmer 2018). In addition to the jingles composed by Minoru Mukaiya, some stations play theme songs depending on the media and its connection to the station. For example, the Takadanobaba station uses the Astro Boy theme because it is considered the birthplace of the popular cartoon series (Sturmer 2018).

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4. Presence of “Kimo-Kawaii” among Japan’s mascots and aesthetics

Sophia remarked on the appearances of the sea life featured in Miyajima aquarium, suggesting that Japan has a habit of applying traditionally cute aesthetics to something unconventional. One Google search later and we discovered “Kimo-Kawaii”, which translates to “creepy-cute” or “gross-cute”. This concept aligned with some of my observations of the mascots or consumer products popular in Japan. I will use the aquarium gift shop as an example. Ranging from plushies to keychains, I perused the options of the various animal merchandise. Some of the options were of conventionally cute animals, such as otters and penguins. Nonetheless, the award for the most outstanding amount of merchandise goes to the garden eel. The garden eel, which may be perceived as creepy to Americans, dominated the store’s

inventory. Another important note to add is that the commercialized image of the garden eel is not an unerring representation of its real appearance. The garden eel products portrayed the sea creature to be colorful with large, glittery eyes and a soft yet elongated silhouette (cute), rather than resorting to a hyperrealistic depiction.

After my visit, I decided to delve deeper into the concept of "kawaii", or kawaii culture. In a survey, both young and mature women were asked to describe their idea of"kawaii" :

> Both young and mature women defined a kawaii article in the same manner: as something small, soft, round, with pastel colors such as light pink and associated with young animals and humans. These visual features trigger a sympathetic and positive response, hence a high amount of both group respondents (n = 375, 54 per cent) stated they 'tend to behave in a friendlier way when observing kawaii articles."(Lieber-Milo 2019, 8).

This excerpt is fascinating for two reasons: it provides an informal definition (or general consensus) of "kawaii" and an insight into how an average person may react to something "kawaii". I would have to agree with these results. Personally, I am not confronted with malice and evil when I cross paths with something fuzzy, starry-eyed, and nauseatingly pink. In the context of "kimo-kawaii" Sanrio's Gudetama character is a convincing example: "...Gudetama's kimokawai (gross cute) images function like Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of carnival, which through folk humor allows a cathartic look at real social problems and the discomfort they cause."(Bonnah 2018, 2). Gudetama's mannerisms and appearance is rooted in nuanced social commentary, but is simplified to convey a sense of "cuteness".

5. Commentary on the deer and Momiji on Miyajima Island

The visit to Miyajima Island was my favorite day abroad. Miyajima is an amalgamation of unique characteristics, including the nonchalant deer and the local delicacy Momiji Manju ("maple leaf bun"). Itsukushima Shrine and the floating Torii gate added elegance and an air of mystique to the island. Overall, the island was quite picturesque. I couldn't help but feel curious about the deer and their origins, or why they exist in a limbo between domesticated and feral. I consulted my artillery of search engines to uncover an answer, yet I couldn't procure a conclusive explanation. In light of my failure, my web-browsing endeavor harbored a publication of different interest, titled "Effects of deer browsing on the early stage of pyrogenic succession on Miyajima Island, southwestern Japan". The paper's contents reminded me of a conversation I had with Sophie (not Sophia) about a deer that attempted to eat her map. In the paper, the authors Toshinori Okuda and Kaneyuki Nakane investigate the effects the deer had on plant regrowth in an area damaged by a fire three years prior. The study concludes that the deer ate 28 percent of the vegetation with a particular hankering for woody plants (Okuda and Nakane 1990, 1). The moral of the story: the insatiable hunger of the Miyajima deer is not to be trifled with.

On the other hand, I successfully found a decently reputable source on the Momiji Manju. Upon my departure from Japan, I realized I had already– regrettably– consumed most of the treats from my box Momiji. Disappointment at my lack of foresight to buy a second box ensued quickly after. The Momiji Manju originated from the Edo period as a regional souvenir, taking inspiration from the island's beauty in its design: "Inspired by the area's stunning autumn leaves, these sweets were shaped like maple leaves and filled with red bean paste."(Krisha 2024). Specifically, the Momiji Manju is a souvenir for visitors of Itsukushima Shrine, but today the treat can be bought anywhere in the general vicinity of Hiroshima. As a brief side note, I do

acknowledge the simplicity of this journal entry in comparison to the other ones. My objective was to reflect on something I enjoyed dearly and discuss it more from a scientific or historical angle. Moreover, I wanted a break from writing on a heavy subject matter. I also just like cute animals and yummy treats.

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